Manufacturing-system coordination of dual-source rotating-chamber semiconductor cluster tools: Integrated operational modeling and exact decision support

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Abstract

Advanced semiconductor processes demand higher throughput, space efficiency, and operating stability from plasma-enhanced chemical vapor deposition (PECVD), prompting the use of multi-space rotating chambers. For the carbon-containing film process studied here, persistent residues expose unoccupied chamber positions to contamination or degradation during processing and cleaning. Reusable dummy wafers therefore fill positions not occupied by products. Products enter from the atmospheric side, whereas dummies are supplied from vacuum storage; the two flows merge at the chamber, creating a dual-source mixed-flow scheduling problem constrained by full occupancy, cleaning, wafer residency, processing cadence, and shared robots. We formulate a source-configurable two-stage mixed-integer linear program using two-wafer PW pairs as transport and occupancy units. The model unifies 4×1 parallel processing, 2×2 chained processing, dummy reuse, and resource conflicts. Stage one minimizes end-to-end makespan. Stage two reduces waiting and cadence variation without changing the discrete plan or makespan. A structure-preserving binary skeleton (SPBS) supplies an initial feasible plan, and RDMCT-HBS selects cuts according to their scheduling roles. Under the same 600-s budget, the two-stage workflow reduces four waiting and cadence measures by 39.70%–94.05%. SPBS raises finite-time incumbent availability from 51.67% to 100% and lowers mean primal–dual integral by 26.19%. Given the same SPBS incumbent, RDMCT-HBS also improves mean primal–dual integral, solution time, terminal relative gap, and proven-optimal rate over HEM-13D. The resulting timelines integrate dummy supply, chamber protection, and product processing, providing verifiable support for material coordination, residency control, and cadence management in PECVD rotating-chamber tools.

Keywords: semiconductor manufacturing system, cluster tool, dual-source material flow, operational decision, mixed-integer linear programming, learning-enhanced exact optimization

1. Introduction

Cluster tools (CTs) are widely used integrated process systems in semiconductor manufacturing. Process modules, load locks, and wafer-handling robots share a controlled environment, shortening transfers between consecutive operations. Chamber time alone does not determine tool output. Wafer release, robot motion, load-lock switching, and chamber occupancy must remain synchronized for the tool to run continuously. Wafer-residency limits, chamber cleaning, and variation in action times further narrow the feasible operating region [1]. CT scheduling must consequently coordinate process, material flow, and control timing rather than merely sequence jobs on parallel machines.

As advanced process flows add more thin-film operations, plasma-enhanced chemical vapor deposition (PECVD) places growing demands on tool throughput, process coverage, and floor-space use. A single-space process module offers limited parallelism. Equipment manufacturers have addressed this constraint by placing several processing spaces in one module and rotating the chamber to exchange the positions accessible to the robot. Several wafers can then be processed while every station remains reachable for handling [2]. This design gives rise to the multi-space rotating-chamber cluster tool considered here.

Higher processing density introduces a chamber-position protection problem. In the carbon-containing film process studied here, deposition residues are difficult to remove. An empty station exposed during processing or cleaning is more susceptible to contamination or condition degradation. The chamber is therefore operated at full occupancy: reusable dummy wafers fill positions not occupied by product wafers and also maintain the required occupancy during cleaning. These dummies circulate among vacuum storage, rotating chambers, and cleaning tasks. Their availability and return times affect when the next product wafers can enter a chamber.

Product wafers travel from atmospheric-side load ports through the ATR, aligner, and load locks, whereas dummies are supplied directly from vacuum-side storage to the VTR. The flows merge at the rotating chamber and compete for the same handling resource, forming dual-source mixed-flow operation. Full occupancy leads to two representative process modes. The 4×1 mode processes four wafers synchronously in one exposure. In the 2×2 mode, two PW pairs move through adjacent chamber cycles so that every product wafer receives two exposures. The modes differ in exposure count, exchange actions,

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and occupancy, and their comparison must distinguish equal single-exposure time from equal total process time. PECVD operation is also sensitive to wafer residency and processing cadence: excessive residence violates time limits, while cadence variation adds waiting and idle resource time. A useful schedule must therefore coordinate completion time, residency waiting, and cadence as well as find a feasible wafer route. Figure 1 shows the equipment topology.

Manufacturing-systems research increasingly places operating decisions within a specific equipment and logistics architecture. Li et al. [3] coordinated processing resources and logistics tasks through a partially decentralized multi-agent system. Zhu et al. [4] represented workstation layout, operation assignment, and transport distance jointly in a matrix manufacturing system. Bhatta and Chang [5] decomposed multi-stage line dynamics to obtain a control representation that transfers across line sizes. The corresponding system boundary here is one dual-source rotating-chamber equipment cell. It receives batch, process-mode, cleaning, and equipment inputs and must return a complete timeline for loading, processing, cleaning, and wafer return.

CT scheduling first developed around throughput analysis and residence-time feasibility. Perkinson et al. [6] related process and transport times to the maximum throughput of a single-wafer CT using an analytical model. Rostami and Hamidzadeh [7] formulated dual-arm scheduling with both process-module and transport-module residency constraints, combining linear programming with problem-specific heuristics. Wu and Zhou [8] used a timed Petri-net steady schedule to derive closed-form schedulability conditions and an optimal periodic schedule. Qiao et al. [9] then extended Petri-net analysis to bounded activity-time variation and obtained an upper bound on wafer sojourn delay for single-arm tools.

Subsequent work broadened the process routes and production mix. Qiao et al. [10] modeled atomic-layer-deposition revisiting and residency constraints in a dual-arm CT and derived an optimal one-wafer cyclic schedule. Wang et al. [11] addressed several wafer types sharing a dual-arm tool under residency limits. Wang et al. [12] introduced a virtual-cell formulation that selects both the number of active process modules and robot waiting times instead of assuming that all modules must be used. At the manufacturing-system level, Lee et al. [13] linked waiting-time violations to yield, buffer design, and upstream-machine control in a Bernoulli production line, showing why equipment scheduling must retain time-window information when system-level performance is evaluated.

As mixed-product, non-cyclic, and multi-tool operation becomes more tightly coupled, deadlock is a central feasibility issue in CT scheduling. A circular wait can arise when wafers occupy process modules or buffers while waiting for a robot whose next action is blocked by another wafer. Zhu et al. [14] studied the shutdown of a two-cluster system after process-module failure under residency constraints, embedded the task synchronization of adjacent robots at a shared buffer into the scheduling model, and derived conditions that prevent buffer deadlock. Kim and Kim [15] addressed non-cyclic scheduling with multiple wafer types, selected robot actions from the

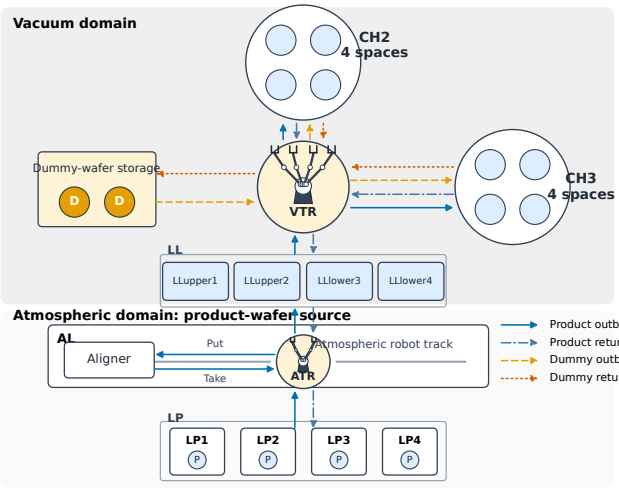


Figure 1: Dual-source mixed-flow cluster tool. The LP bank is centred below the vertically aligned ATR and VTR. The dual-hand ATR performs LP pickup, aligner place–then–pick handling, and product return; the VTR has four hands, and the fork grippers of both robots face the chamber-access direction. Solid, dash-dot, dashed, and dotted arrows denote product outbound, product return, dummy outbound, and dummy return routes. Storage–VTR, VTR–rotary-chamber, and ATR–LP links all show separate outbound and return paths. The tool may contain multiple rotary chambers; two four-space chambers are illustrated.

dynamic equipment state, and explicitly excluded actions leading to deadlock. These studies mark a shift from fixed cyclic sequences toward explicit representations of dynamic state, shared resources, and inter-tool synchronization. In the dual-source rotating-chamber system studied here, reusable dummies, four-position full occupancy, $4 \times 1/2 \times 2$ mode changes, cleaning, and the shared VTR create analogous cross-route coupling; deadlock avoidance must therefore be embedded in the finite-batch schedule rather than treated as a separate control rule.

Cleaning added a second line of constraints because a maintenance action occupies chambers and changes the robot sequence. Kim et al. [16] generated feasible dual-arm robot-task sequences for periodic chamber cleaning and used heuristics when complete enumeration became expensive. Yu and Lee [17] combined partial loading with robot-task timing control to reduce both cycle time and wafer delay in dual-arm tools with cleaning. Qiao et al. [18] represented cleaning occupancy with virtual wafers and optimized a residency-constrained dual-arm CT using binary integer programming. Li et al. [19] linked cleaning triggers to chamber condition and derived feasible schedules for time-constrained single-arm tools.

Recent studies have moved toward richer equipment configurations and mixed production. Gu et al. [20] used linear programming to obtain minimum steady-state cycles for a four-finger robot and four-space modules. Yang et al. [21] used MIP to determine release and robot-task sequences jointly for two wafer types. These advances still leave a distinct finite-batch problem in which two external sources feed the same vacuum domain, reusable dummies enforce full occupancy, and 4×1 and 2×2 rotary recipes coexist.

Learning-based CT controllers operate at a different decision layer. Kim and Lee [22] combined deep reinforcement learning with look-ahead search to select non-cyclic actions. Hong et al. [23] trained DDPG in a discrete-event model to adjust PVD process times. Here, processing times are inputs and the output must be a complete schedule with MILP feasibility checks, bounds, and an optimality status. Learning-enhanced exact optimization therefore provides a more suitable interface. Tang et al. [24] formulated cut selection as reinforcement learning. Huang et al. [25] learned candidate-cut rankings. Paulus et al. [26] used a strong look-ahead rule to generate imitation targets. Wang et al. [27] used a hierarchical policy to select both the cut budget and an ordered cut subset.

Existing studies address residency, cleaning, revisiting, mixed-product release, and learning-based control separately, but do not cover the combined dual-source supply and full-occupancy requirements of a PECVD rotating chamber. Dummy wafers occupy chamber positions during both product processing and cleaning. Their closed route is coupled with the product route through the shared VTR and chamber stations, so a local sequencing change can alter residency waiting, processing cadence, and even batch feasibility. The model also combines discrete routing choices with continuous event times, making it difficult to obtain both a good feasible plan and a tight dual bound within a fixed decision time. This study addresses these gaps through the following contributions:

1. a source-configurable MILP that unifies the single-source specialization and dual-source mixed flow, $4\times1/2\times2$ modes, reusable dummies, cleaning, residency, robot use, and load-lock occupancy as a state–event model of the equipment cell;

2. a throughput-first, operational-quality-second mechanism that maps equipment and recipe inputs to an end-to-end timeline and reduces residency waiting and processing-cadence variation while preserving the current makespan; and

3. an exact decision engine combining an SPBS initial plan with the RDMCT-HBS cut selector. SPBS uses equipment structure to construct an admissible discrete operating skeleton, while RDMCT-HBS augments HEM's hierarchical count–sequence framework with role-aware representation, grouped gated encoding, beam search, and policy-anchored structural completion to improve finite-time plan delivery and bound convergence without changing the MILP feasible region or proof logic.

The paper follows an evidence chain from manufacturing-system abstraction to an operational model, an exact decision engine, and system experiments. Section 2 maps equipment topology, the two material flows, and control actions into the MILP. Section 3 develops SPBS and the structure-aware cut selector. Section 4 examines process modes, operating quality, plan delivery, solver status, and changes in scale and operating parameters. Section 5 summarizes the integration and operational implications.

2. Manufacturing-system architecture, material flow, and two-stage operational model

2.1. PW-pair modeling for the two process modes

The equipment cell is represented as a three-layer mapping from configuration inputs through operating decisions to execution outputs. Inputs include product wafer counts and modes, material-source interfaces, equipment action times, cleaning intervals, residency limits, load-lock capacity, and dummy inventory. The operating decisions jointly determine product and dummy routes, the start and finish of every physical action, and the order of shared-resource use. The output is a complete finite-batch timeline together with its feasibility and optimality status. The boundary covers the product path from an LP through processing and back to an LP and the closed dummy loop from vacuum storage through filling or cleaning and back to storage. No buffer outside the LP, aligner, load locks, rotating chambers, and dummy storage is assumed; every wait therefore corresponds to an explicit physical-occupancy interval.

A wafer pair (PW pair) is a physical two-wafer transport and chamber-occupancy unit. Its members may be product+product (product PW pair), dummy+dummy (dummy PW pair), or product+dummy (mixed PW pair). Product wafers are preferentially paired by mode and index; an odd tail product may be paired with one dummy, while full-occupancy filling and cleaning may use dummy PW pairs. The sets $\mathcal{P}^F$ and $\mathcal{P}^L$ index product-containing PW pairs, including product PW pairs and any required mixed PW pairs. Alignment and residency remain wafer-level operations; the two members share a time window only on a selected two-hand transfer or the same chamber side. Preprocessing maps equivalent product-containing PW pairs to canonical compatible positions. This removes label-swapping symmetry but leaves active batches or chain positions, physical dummy identities, paired transfers, resource order, and all event times to the MILP. Legal cleaning segments are generated from the cleaning interval and complete recipe boundaries, after which the MILP activates the cleaning tasks and schedules their times.

A product follows LP–ATR–AL–ATR–upper load lock–VTR–rotary chamber–VTR–lower load lock–ATR–LP: the ATR first places the wafer on the aligner, then retrieves it for transfer into the vacuum domain. A dummy travels from vacuum storage through the VTR to the chamber and returns through the VTR after use. A regular all-product 4×1 batch contains two product PW pairs, hence four product wafers, and processes all four positions synchronously once before last-in–first-out unloading; only the last incomplete batch may use a dummy or mixed PW pair to fill all positions. In 2×2, every product-containing PW pair occupies two adjacent process cycles so that each of its product members is processed twice. For three product PW pairs, a dummy PW pair D is loaded first, the chamber rotates, and P1 is loaded before D+P1 undergoes chamber processing. Chamber processing then alternates with "chamber rotation + chain slide", changing the occupancy successively to P1+P2, P2+P3, and P3+D; P1, P2, and P3 are each processed twice before all wafers are unloaded. Figures 2 and 3 show the event sequences.

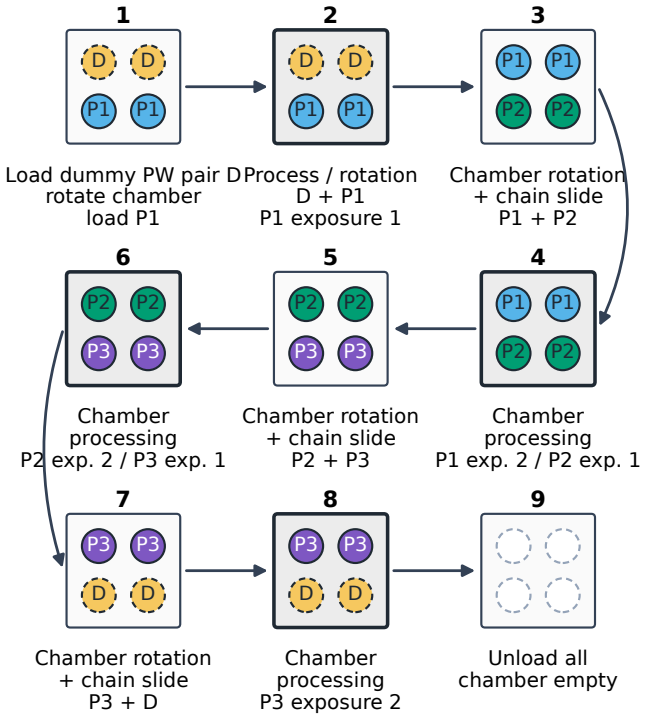


Figure 2: 2×2 chained processing. A PW pair may be P+P, D+D, or P+D; here each Pi is a P+P product PW pair and D is a D+D dummy PW pair. Step 1 loads D, rotates the chamber, and loads P1; Step 2 performs chamber processing on D+P1; Step 3 applies chamber rotation + chain slide to obtain P1+P2. Repeating "chamber processing–chamber rotation + chain slide" makes P1, P2, and P3 participate in two adjacent process cycles, so every product wafer is processed twice before all wafers are unloaded.

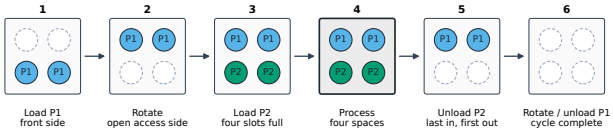


Figure 3: 4×1 parallel processing. A regular all-product batch uses two product PW pairs, comprising four product wafers, and receives one synchronous full-occupancy process before last-in–first-out unloading; a dummy or mixed PW pair can complete the final short batch.

Tables 1 and 2 list every symbol in the core formulation and distinguish sets/indices, input constants, fixed binary aliases, binary decisions, continuous decisions, and derived quantities. In the implementation, x^F and x^L are continuous $[0, 1]$ aliases fixed to zero or one by equality; this preserves uniform export names without creating extra branching decisions. To fit the official double-column template, the complete notation is divided into two full-width tables without deleting entries.

2.2. *Source interfaces, operation activation, and time relations*

The fixed incidence parameter satisfies

$$\sum_{s \in \mathcal{S}} \chi_{is} = 1, \qquad i \in \mathcal{I}. \tag{1}$$

Equation (1) assigns each material unit to exactly one source. Setting $|\mathcal{S}| = 1$ gives the single-source tool; using two interfaces and assigning products and dummies to different interfaces gives the dual-source tool.

If $\mathcal{A}^{\text{int}}$ is the internal network and $\mathcal{A}_s$ contains release and return arcs for source s, then

$$\mathcal{A} = \mathcal{A}^{\text{int}} \cup \left(\bigcup_{s \in \mathcal{S}} \mathcal{A}_s \right). \tag{2}$$

Equation (2) means that one- and two-source tools differ only at route endpoints; processing, cleaning, shared resources, and timing use the same internal model, so a dual-source tool is not the sum of two independent single-source schedules.

Canonical pair positions satisfy

$$\begin{aligned} x^F_{pcbl} &= \bar{x}^F_{pcbl}, \quad \sum_{c,b,l} x^F_{pcbl} = 1 \quad (p \in \mathcal{P}^F), \\ x^L_{pck} &= \bar{x}^L_{pck}, \quad \sum_{c,k} x^L_{pck} = 1 \quad (p \in \mathcal{P}^L). \end{aligned} \tag{3}$$

Equation (3) assigns each wafer pair to one compatible position and fixes equivalent locations to canonical indices. It removes label symmetry, not event times or resource order.

A position containing a pair must be active, and candidate positions are used consecutively:

$$\begin{aligned} x^F_{pcbl} &\le u^F_{cb}, \quad u^F_{c,b+1} \le u^F_{cb}, \\ x^L_{pck} &\le u^L_{ck}, \quad u^L_{c,k+1} \le u^L_{ck}. \end{aligned} \tag{4}$$

Equation (4) activates any batch or chain position containing a product and excludes a nonphysical inactive position followed by an active one.

For each candidate operation o, activation and duration satisfy

$$0 \le s_o \le M b_o, \qquad 0 \le e_o \le M b_o, \qquad e_o = s_o + d_o b_o. \tag{5}$$

Equation (5) sets inactive operation times to zero and gives an active operation duration d_o. It applies to robot moves, alignment, pump/vent, rotation, product processing, dummy transport, and cleaning.

For every required process arc $(o, o') \in \mathcal{A}$,

$$b_{o'} \le b_o, \qquad s_{o'} \ge e_o + \delta_{oo'} - M(2 - b_o - b_{o'}). \tag{6}$$

Equation (6) activates a successor only with its predecessor and, when both exist, starts it after the predecessor and minimum lag. These arcs connect product routes, dummy routes, and load–process–unload chains.

Table 1: Core notation I: sets, indices, and input parameters

Symbol	Domain and role	Meaning
$\mathcal{S}, \mathcal{I}$	sets/indices	Material-source interfaces and material units; $i \in \mathcal{I}$ may be a product or dummy demand.
$\mathcal{W}$	set/index	Product wafers, indexed by w.
$\mathcal{P}^F, \mathcal{P}^L$	sets/indices	Product-containing PW pairs assigned to 4×1 and 2×2; they include P+P product pairs and any required P+D mixed pairs, indexed by p.
$\mathcal{C}$	set/index	Rotary process chambers, indexed by c.
$\mathcal{B}_c, \mathcal{K}_c$	ordered sets/indices	Candidate 4×1 batches b and 2×2 product-chain positions k in chamber c.
$\mathcal{L} = \{1, 2\}$	set/index	Front and back sides of a 4×1 batch.
$\mathcal{Q}_c, \mathcal{E}_c$	ordered sets/indices	2×2 process cycles q and cleaning segments e in chamber c.
$\mathcal{V}_c$	set/index	Union of all 4×1 batches and 2×2 cycles in chamber c.
$\mathcal{O}, \mathcal{A}$	sets/indices	Candidate physical operations and required process-precedence arcs.
$\mathcal{R}, \Lambda_r$	sets/indices	Shared resources and physical slots of resource r.
$\mathcal{J}_c^D, \mathcal{T}_c$	sets/indices	Dummy-wafer demands and reusable physical dummies of chamber c.
χ_{is}	known binary constant	Whether material unit i belongs to source interface s.
$\bar{x}^F_{pcbl}, \bar{x}^L_{pck}$	known binary constants	Canonical pair-to-4×1-side or pair-to-2×2-position assignment.
$q_c^-(k), q_c^+(k)$	known nonnegative integer maps	First and second process cycles of 2×2 chain position k, with $q_c^+(k) = q_c^-(k) + 1$.
$\bar{z}_{ce}, \bar{a}^F_{cbe}, \bar{a}^L_{cqe}$	known binary constants	Active cleaning segments and pre-generated membership of batches or cycles.
$H, \bar{Q}_c$	nonnegative integer constants	Maximum cycles between cleanings and generated 2×2 cycles in chamber c.
$d_o, \delta_{oo'}$	nonnegative constants	Duration of operation o and minimum lag on arc (o, o').
d^F_ν, d^L, r_c	nonnegative constants	4×1 stage duration, 2×2 process time, and chamber half-rotation time.
$\rho^r_{oo'}$	nonnegative constant	Empty travel or reset time from operation o to o' on resource r.
$M, \bar{R}_{wr}$	positive constants	Valid horizon-based big-M and maximum residency of wafer w in restricted region r.
κ_o, Γ_o	integer/set constants	Slots required by operation o and the slots it may use.
$\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_4$	nonnegative constants	Stage-two weights for total wait, maximum wait, cadence deviation, and soft-limit excess.
$\bar{\omega}_\alpha, \varepsilon_C$	nonnegative constants	Soft limit for wait α and the stage-two makespan tolerance.
$\mathcal{F}, \mathcal{D}_{\text{fix}}$	sets	Full MILP feasible region and discrete indices fixed in stage two.
$\mathcal{Q}^w, \mathcal{I}_h$	sets/indices	Wait quantities and process starts admitting cadence second differences.

2.3. *Occupancy and event order in the two processing modes*

For 4×1, let $A^F_{cb} = \sum_{p,l} x^F_{pcbl}$ be the number of product pairs assigned to batch (c, b). Full occupancy and dummy filling are

$$\begin{aligned} A^F_{cb} &= \sum_{p \in \mathcal{P}^F} \sum_{l \in \mathcal{L}} x^F_{pcbl}, \\ \sum_{p \in \mathcal{P}^F} x^F_{pcbl} + f^F_{cbl} &= u^F_{cb} \qquad (l \in \mathcal{L}), \\ \sum_{l \in \mathcal{L}} f^F_{cbl} &= 2u^F_{cb} - A^F_{cb}. \end{aligned} \tag{7}$$

Equation (7) gives each active 4×1 batch two sides, each occupied by one product pair or one dummy pair; all four chamber positions are therefore filled at process start.

Active batches are consecutive and dummy filling is restricted to the last active batch:

$$\begin{aligned} A^F_{cb} &\geq u^F_{cb}, & u^F_{c,b+1} &\leq u^F_{cb}, \\ A^F_{cb} &\geq 2u^F_{c,b+1}, & t^F_{cb} &\leq u^F_{cb}, \\ t^F_{cb} &\leq 1 - u^F_{c,b+1}, & t^F_{cb} &\geq u^F_{cb} - u^F_{c,b+1}. \end{aligned} \tag{8}$$

Equation (8) requires at least one product pair in an active batch and two product pairs if a later batch is active. The last three inequalities set $t^F_{cb} = 1$ exactly at the active tail; the final candidate uses $t^F_{cB} = u^F_{cB}$.

Let FL, BL, P, BU, FU denote front load, back load, processing, back unload, and front unload. Then

$$\begin{aligned} e^{F,\nu}_{cb} &= s^{F,\nu}_{cb} + d^F_\nu u^F_{cb} && (\nu \in \{FL, BL, P, BU, FU\}), \\ s^{F,BL}_{cb} &\geq e^{F,FL}_{cb} + r_c - M(1 - u^F_{cb}), \\ s^{F,P}_{cb} &= e^{F,BL}_{cb}, \\ s^{F,BU}_{cb} &\geq e^{F,P}_{cb} - M(1 - u^F_{cb}), \\ s^{F,FU}_{cb} &\geq e^{F,BU}_{cb} + r_c - M(1 - u^F_{cb}). \end{aligned} \tag{9}$$

Equation (9) loads the front side, rotates to load the back, starts synchronous processing after the back load, and then unloads the back side before rotating and unloading the front. Consecutive batches are linked by $s^{F,FL}_{c,b+1} \geq e^{F,FU}_{cb} - M(1 - u^F_{c,b+1})$.

For 2×2, each product pair occupies one ordered chain position:

$$u^L_{ck} = \sum_{p \in \mathcal{P}^L} x^L_{pck}, \qquad u^L_{c,k+1} \leq u^L_{ck}, \qquad a^L_c = u^L_{c1}. \tag{10}$$

Equation (10) creates a one-to-one relation between product pairs and consecutive chain positions and uses a^L_c to indicate whether chamber c contains a 2×2 chain.

Let $q_c^-(k)$ and $q_c^+(k)$ denote the first and second process cycles of chain position k. The pair–cycle incidence is

$$\begin{aligned} q_c^+(k) &= q_c^-(k) + 1, \\ \mu^L_{pcq} &= \sum_{\substack{k \in \mathcal{K}_c: \\ q \in \{q_c^-(k), q_c^+(k)\}}} x^L_{pck}, \\ \sum_{q \in \mathcal{Q}_c} \mu^L_{pcq} &= 2 \sum_{k \in \mathcal{K}_c} x^L_{pck}. \end{aligned} \tag{11}$$

Equation (11) maps every assigned 2×2 product-containing PW pair to exactly two adjacent process cycles. Every product member inherits the same μ^L_{pcq} incidence, so a product is not omitted even when an odd tail uses a P+D mixed PW pair. The equation also distinguishes the modes explicitly: a 2×2 product-containing pair spans two cycles, whereas two 4×1 side pairs are processed once in one full batch.

The generated layout supplies the number $\bar{Q}_c$ of process cy-

Table 2: Core notation II: decision variables, fixed aliases, and derived quantities

Symbol	Domain and role	Meaning
x^F_{pcbl}, x^L_{pck}	fixed continuous $[0,1]$ aliases	Product-containing PW-pair placement on a 4×1 batch side or at a 2×2 chain position.
μ^L_{pcq}	fixed continuous $[0,1]$ alias	Whether 2×2 product-containing PW pair p is processed in cycle q of chamber c.
$u^F_{cb}, f^F_{cbl}, t^F_{cb}$	binary variables	4×1 batch activation, dummy filling on a side, and final active batch.
$u^L_{ck}, a^L_c, v^L_{cq}, h^L_{ck}$	binary variables	2×2 position, chain, process-cycle, and chain-tail activation.
$z_{ce}, a^F_{cbe}, a^L_{cqe}, q^{\mathrm{cl}}_{ch}$	fixed-binary aliases/variables	Cleaning segments, task membership, and cleaning-task activation.
$q_j, g_{j\tau}$	binary variables	Dummy demand and assignment to physical dummy τ.
$b_o, y^r_{oo'}$	binary variables	Operation activation and whether o precedes o' on resource r.
$h_{o\ell}$	binary slot variable	Whether operation o occupies physical slot ℓ.
γ_{pa}	binary variable	Whether pair p uses one paired transfer on robot route a.
s_o, e_o	nonnegative variables	Start and end times of operation o.
$s^{F,v}, e^{F,v}, s^L, e^L$	continuous aliases	Stage-specific notation for s_o, e_o in the two modes.
A^F_{cb}, N_{ce}	derived continuous/integer quantities	Product-pair count in a 4×1 batch and active cycles in a cleaning segment.
a_{vce}	fixed binary alias	Whether task $v\in\mathcal{V}_c$ belongs to cleaning segment e.
$C_w, C_{\max}$	nonnegative variables	Product completion time and lot makespan.
$\omega_\alpha, L_{\mathrm{sum}}, L_{\max}$	nonnegative variables/derived quantities	Stage-two wait or idle quantities, their sum, and their maximum.
$\Delta_{ceq}, v_{ceq}, \eta_\alpha$	derived/nonnegative variables	Cadence second difference, its absolute-value bound, and soft wait excess.
h_{ceq}, Φ	continuous alias/derived objective	Start of the qth process in a segment and stage-two schedule-quality objective.
$\xi, \widehat{\xi}, \widehat{C}$	vector/stage constants	Current variables, stage-one incumbent, and incumbent makespan.

cles, and h^L_{ck} identifies the chain tail:

$$
\begin{aligned}
v^L_{cq} &= \begin{cases} a^L_c, & q \le \bar{Q}_c, \\ 0, & q > \bar{Q}_c, \end{cases} \\
\sum_k h^L_{ck} = a^L_c, \qquad & h^L_{ck} \le u^L_{ck}, \qquad h^L_{ck} + u^L_{c,k+1} \le 1, \\
& h^L_{ck} \ge u^L_{ck} - u^L_{c,k+1}.
\end{aligned}
\tag{12}
$$

Equation (12) gives $n+1$ process cycles for a segment with n product-containing PW pairs: the head is dummy PW pair+P1, internal cycles are Pi+P$i+1$, and the tail is Pn+dummy PW pair. The final relations make h^L_{ck} one only at the last active product position.

For a legal chain segment $(q_0,\dots,q_T)$, let H_0, B_q, and T_0 denote head loading, internal exchange, and tail unloading. Then

$$
\begin{aligned}
e^L_{cq} - s^L_{cq} &= d^L v^L_{cq}, \\
s^L_{cq_0} &= e^{H_0}_c, \\
s^B_{cq} \ge e^L_{c,q-1} - M(1-a^L_c), \qquad & s^L_{cq} = e^B_{cq} \quad (q_0 < q \le q_T), \\
s^{T_0}_c \ge e^L_{cq_T} - M(1-a^L_c).
\end{aligned}
\tag{13}
$$

Equation (13) begins the first process immediately after head loading, performs an internal exchange only after the previous cycle, and unloads the tail only after the last process. It directly realizes dummy+P1, P1+P2, …, Pn+dummy.

2.4. Cleaning and reusable dummy wafers

Cleaning segments are generated from H and complete process boundaries and enter the MILP as fixed binary aliases:

$$
z_{ce} = \bar{z}_{ce}, \qquad a^F_{cbe} = \bar{a}^F_{cbe} u^F_{cb}, \qquad a^L_{cqe} = \bar{a}^L_{cqe} v^L_{cq}. \tag{14}
$$

Equation (14) prevents arbitrary cleaning locations: 4×1 may split only at batch boundaries and 2×2 only after a complete chain segment, while the MILP still schedules process and cleaning times.

Let N_{ce} be the number of active process cycles in segment e:

$$
\begin{aligned}
N_{ce} = \sum_b a^F_{cbe} + \sum_q a^L_{cqe}, \qquad & z_{ce} \le N_{ce} \le H z_{ce}, \\
q^{\mathrm{cl}}_{ch} = z_{c,h+1}.
\end{aligned}
\tag{15}
$$

Equation (15) places at least one and at most H process cycles in an active segment and activates cleaning between every pair of consecutive active segments.

Let $\mathcal{V}_c$ be the union of 4×1 batches and 2×2 cycles and let a_{vce} take the corresponding a^F or a^L. Cleaning order and the physical cleaning chain satisfy

$$
\begin{aligned}
s_v &\ge e^{\mathrm{cl}}_{c,e-1} - M(1-a_{vce}) && (e>1), \\
e_v &\le s^{\mathrm{cl}}_{ce} + M(1-a_{vce}) + M(1-q^{\mathrm{cl}}_{ce}), \\
s^{\mathrm{cl,BL}}_{ce} &\ge e^{\mathrm{cl,FL}}_{ce} + r_c - M(1-q^{\mathrm{cl}}_{ce}), \\
s^{\mathrm{cl,P}}_{ce} &\ge e^{\mathrm{cl,BL}}_{ce} - M(1-q^{\mathrm{cl}}_{ce}), \\
s^{\mathrm{cl,BU}}_{ce} &\ge e^{\mathrm{cl,P}}_{ce} - M(1-q^{\mathrm{cl}}_{ce}), \\
s^{\mathrm{cl,FU}}_{ce} &\ge e^{\mathrm{cl,BU}}_{ce} + r_c - M(1-q^{\mathrm{cl}}_{ce}).
\end{aligned}
\tag{16}
$$

Equation (16) starts a segment after the preceding cleaning and finishes it before the next cleaning. A cleaning task loads both chamber sides with dummies, rotates, processes, and unloads in reverse, thereby occupying the VTR, chamber, and four physical dummies rather than adding virtual downtime.

Dummy demand j is activated by a physical event:

$$
q_j = \begin{cases} f^F_{cbl}, & j \text{ is a final-}4\times1 \text{ filling demand}, \\ a^L_c, & j \text{ is a } 2\times2 \text{ head or tail demand}, \\ q^{\mathrm{cl}}_{ch}, & j \text{ is a cleaning demand}. \end{cases} \tag{17}
$$

Equation (17) prevents dummies from becoming an unlimited abstract filler: a physical demand exists only for a final batch, chain head/tail, or active cleaning task.

Each active demand selects one physical dummy from inventory:

$$
\sum_{\tau\in\mathcal{T}_c} g_{j\tau} = q_j, \qquad j \in \mathcal{J}^D_c. \tag{18}
$$

Equation (18) assigns every active demand exactly once. Mutual exclusion subsequently orders repeated uses of the same physical dummy, so it can be reused only after unloading and return to storage.

2.5. Robots, load locks, chambers, and time resources

ATR, AL, VTR, and each rotary chamber are unary resources; the upper and lower load locks each have two physical slots; each dummy in inventory is a reusable slot. An operation o requiring κ_o slots satisfies

$$\sum_{\ell \in \Gamma_o} h_{o\ell} = \kappa_o b_o. \tag{19}$$

Equation (19) assigns an active operation the required number of legal physical slots and assigns none to an inactive operation. AL, ATR, VTR, and a chamber have one slot, while load locks and dummy inventory retain physical identities.

If operations o and o' may compete for slot ℓ of resource r, then

$$\begin{aligned} s_{o'} &\geq e_o + \rho^r_{oo'} - M(1 - y^r_{oo'}) - M(1 - h_{o\ell}) - M(1 - h_{o'\ell}), \\ s_o &\geq e_{o'} + \rho^r_{o'o} - M y^r_{oo'} - M(1 - h_{o\ell}) - M(1 - h_{o'\ell}). \end{aligned} \tag{20}$$

Equation (20) makes $y^r_{oo'}$ choose one order whenever two actions use the same slot and includes empty robot travel or equipment reset through $\rho^r_{oo'}$. It applies to ATR, AL, both load locks, VTR, rotary chambers, and individual dummies, preventing concurrent robot actions and reuse before release.

An individual product or dummy stage must coincide with its selected batch, chain position, or cleaning window. For selection x and reference stage $[s^{\mathrm{ref}}, e^{\mathrm{ref}}]$,

$$\begin{aligned} -M(1 - x) \leq s_o - s^{\mathrm{ref}} \leq M(1 - x), \\ -M(1 - x) \leq e_o - e^{\mathrm{ref}} \leq M(1 - x). \end{aligned} \tag{21}$$

Equation (21) synchronizes the individual action with its physical stage when $x = 1$ and releases the candidate relation when $x = 0$, connecting pair positions, product routes, dummy demands, and chamber windows.

If pair p uses one paired transfer on robot route a, the two wafer stages are synchronized:

$$\begin{aligned} -M(1 - \gamma_{pa}) \leq s_{w_1 a} - s_{w_2 a} \leq M(1 - \gamma_{pa}), \\ -M(1 - \gamma_{pa}) \leq e_{w_1 a} - e_{w_2 a} \leq M(1 - \gamma_{pa}). \end{aligned} \tag{22}$$

Equation (22) means that $\gamma_{pa} = 1$ moves a complete pair in one non-preemptive robot action. If $\gamma_{pa} = 0$, the wafers still occupy the same robot separately and are ordered by Eq. (20).

For the entry and exit events of wafer w in restricted equipment region r,

$$0 \leq s_{\mathrm{out}(w,r)} - e_{\mathrm{in}(w,r)} \leq \overline{R}_{wr}. \tag{23}$$

Equation (23) limits the physical stay in an upper load lock, chamber, lower load lock, or restricted transport region. Load-lock occupation also spans placement, pump/vent, opposite-side pickup, and pressure reset, so placement by a robot is not mistaken for slot release.

2.6. Throughput-first and schedule-quality-second optimization

Let C_w be the time at which product wafer w completes the lower-load-lock return and reaches its load port. Stage one solves

$$C_w = e_{w,\mathrm{return}}, \qquad C_{\max} \geq C_w \ (w \in \mathcal{W}), \qquad \min_{\xi \in \mathcal{F}} C_{\max}. \tag{24}$$

Equation (24) measures makespan over the complete end-to-end route rather than at the last chamber operation. The feasible region $\mathcal{F}$ consists of Eqs. (1)–(23) expanded over all applicable indices.

Given stage-one incumbent $\widehat{\xi}$ and makespan $\widehat{C}$, stage two fixes the discrete structure indexed by $\mathcal{D}_{\mathrm{fix}}$ and minimizes linear schedule quality within the makespan tolerance:

$$\begin{aligned} \xi_d = \widehat{\xi}_d \quad (d \in \mathcal{D}_{\mathrm{fix}}), \qquad C_{\max} \leq \widehat{C} + \varepsilon_C, \\ L_{\mathrm{sum}} = \sum_{\alpha \in Q^w} \omega_\alpha, qquad L_{\max} \geq \omega_\alpha, \\ \Delta_{ceq} = (h_{ce,q+1} - h_{ceq}) - (h_{ceq} - h_{ce,q-1}), \\ v_{ceq} \geq \Delta_{ceq}, \qquad v_{ceq} \geq -\Delta_{ceq}, \\ \eta_\alpha \geq \omega_\alpha - \bar{\omega}_\alpha, qquad \eta_\alpha \geq 0, \\ \min \Phi = \lambda_1 L_{\mathrm{sum}} + \lambda_2 L_{\max} + \lambda_3 \sum_{(c,e,q) \in \mathcal{I}_h} v_{ceq} + \lambda_4 \sum_{\alpha \in Q^w} \eta_\alpha. \end{aligned} \tag{25}$$

Equation (25) preserves the stage-one makespan and principal discrete routes and resource orders while reducing total wait, maximum wait, interval variation within a cleaning segment, and optional soft-limit excess. The experiments use $(\lambda_1, \lambda_2, \lambda_3) = (1, 10, 25)$ and $\varepsilon_C = 10^{-6}$; the soft wait limit is disabled.

2.7. Coverage and model boundary

After index expansion, Eqs. (1)–(25) jointly describe the finite-batch dual-source problem with mixed $4 \times 1/2 \times 2$ operation, periodic cleaning, and finite dummy inventory. Equations (1)–(2) encode source interfaces: one interface is single source, while two interfaces with products and dummies assigned separately are dual source. Equations (3)–(6) encode locations, activation, durations, and precedence for product-containing PW pairs. Equations (7)–(9) encode a 4×1 full batch formed by two chamber-side PW pairs, final-batch filling, rotation, and last-in–first-out unloading. Equations (10)–(13) encode the consecutive 2×2 chain, two adjacent exposures per product-containing PW pair, dummy-PW-pair head/tail filling, and internal exchange. Equations (14)–(16) encode legal cleaning boundaries, segment capacity, and the physical cleaning chain. Equations (17)–(18) encode dummy demand and finite inventory. Equations (19)–(23) encode mutual exclusion of robots, load locks, chambers, and dummies, paired transfer, and residency. Equations (24)–(25) encode end-to-end makespan followed by wait/cadence refinement. A pure mode is obtained by making the other mode set empty.

Every active material route has a finite precedence chain from release to return, and every pair of operations competing

for one resource must be ordered. If those inequalities formed a directed cycle, summing them would require an event to occur later than itself by a positive duration, so the combination is infeasible. The resource-ordering and process-precedence constraints therefore eliminate circular waits from the schedule.

The model boundary is explicit: preprocessing fixes wafer pairing, equivalent chamber sides, and legal cleaning segments; action times are deterministic within a solve; random failures and real-time rescheduling are excluded. These choices retain the central coupling among sources, modes, dummies, cleaning, and shared resources while removing label permutations with no physical distinction.

3. Structure-aware exact solution for verifiable operational decisions

The model in Section 2 must return an executable equipment timeline within a given decision window, rather than only an objective value. On the primal side, full occupancy, dual-source logistics, and shared-resource order can delay the first competitive feasible plan. On the dual side, generic cut scores do not reveal whether a cut mainly tightens discrete choices, continuous event times, or their coupling. We first construct a feasible starting point with a structure-preserving binary skeleton (SPBS), and then use RDMCT-HBS to select cuts in SCIP separation callbacks. SPBS improves finite-time plan availability, and RDMCT-HBS promotes bound convergence, while SCIP retains responsibility for feasibility checks, valid-cut generation, bounds, and optimality proofs [28, 29].

The complete workflow comprises six stages: construct and validate an initial solution, generate candidate cuts, predict the cut count, search for an ordered cut set, complete its structure, and resume exact search. The learning component neither generates inequalities nor changes candidate-cut coefficients; it determines only the retained prefix and input order of rows already validated by SCIP. This interface confines data-driven decisions to search control and separates learning gains from schedule feasibility and optimality certification.

3.1. SPBS initial solution

SPBS does not guess every event time. It first fixes the discrete skeleton that can be inferred reliably from the recipe. Product wafers are paired in input order. The 4×1 pairs are mapped sequentially to chambers, batches, and front/back positions, whereas the 2×2 pairs are assigned round-robin to chamber-chain positions. This determines batch-use, tail-batch, used-position, and last-position indicators. Cleaning counts partition each chamber sequence into process segments: 4×1 batches are assigned to their cleaning epochs, while a 2×2 chain ends its current segment with process-enabling carriers (PECs) when the cleaning threshold is reached and resumes after cleaning with a new PEC-bounded head. The skeleton therefore determines what is processed, in which chamber, and at which legal cleaning boundary; detailed PEC occupancy and all continuous event times remain governed by the MILP.

At the resource level, SPBS derives a conservative order from the same physical route. ATR first schedules 4×1 inputs and returns across chambers and stages the first 2×2 pair of a chamber immediately after that chamber's final full batch. It then advances chain inputs and returns segment by segment. Deterministic odd/even load-lock slots break slot symmetry, and the VTR order is aligned with ATR batch progression and cleaning actions. Let $\mathcal{F}_q$ be the binary variables fixed in relaxation profile q, with skeleton value $\widehat{x}_j$. The temporary model imposes

$$\ell_j^{(q)} = u_j^{(q)} = \widehat{x}_j, \qquad j \in \mathcal{F}_q. \tag{26}$$

Equation (26) fixes only the binary choices regarded as reliable in the current profile. Start, completion, and waiting times, together with resource orders outside that profile, remain free.

If the strict skeleton does not yield a feasible solution within its budget, SPBS enlarges the search space through five implemented profiles. First, `spbs_full` fixes product/batch assignment, activation, cleaning epochs, load-lock slots, ATR/AL/LL order, and VTR order. Second, `spbs_relaxed_vtr` releases the high-risk VTR order. Third, `spbs_relaxed_ll` additionally releases load-lock order. Fourth, `spbs_fixed_slots` releases ATR, AL, and all remaining resource orders but retains structural assignments and slots. Fifth, `spbs_structure_only` also releases slots, leaving only assignment, activation, and cleaning structure fixed. For instances of at least 32 wafers, the implementation begins from fixed-slot or structure-only profiles so that more time is available for feasibility search; under a tight waiting-time cap it also retains a fully unfixed `spbs_unrestricted` attempt.

Every profile rebuilds a temporary model, sets the objective to zero, uses feasibility emphasis, aggressive heuristics, fast presolve, no separation, and stops at the first solution. Once a physical schedule is found, the program reconstructs the full model, fixes its principal discrete and continuous values, releases only secondary stability auxiliaries, completes them, and invokes the complete SCIP solution check. Only a checked high-precision solution file is passed to the production model as an incumbent. No SPBS bound is transferred, so the production solve remains free to improve the schedule and complete the global proof. In the formal benchmark SPBS is precomputed offline; its metadata records the accepted profile and all attempts, and a SHA-256 hash of the serialized LP prevents a start from being reused on a different model. Its construction cost is excluded from reported PDI and main-solve time.

3.2. HEM baseline and role-aware representation

Prior learning-based cut selectors address generic candidate sets with reinforcement learning, learned ranking, and look-ahead imitation [24–26]. HEM further identifies three coupled decisions—which cuts, how many cuts, and in what order—and handles them with a high-level count policy and a low-level sequence policy [27]. We retain HEM's hierarchical decomposition and pointer decoding and use its 13D implementation as the direct baseline. Training instances, budgets, random seeds, candidate limits, and hidden dimensions are shared; only the input representation and post-selection completion are changed.

The 13D HEM candidate vector comprises objective parallelism, efficacy, normalized support, integral-support ratio, nor-

malized violation, the mean/maximum/minimum/standard deviation of row coefficients, and the corresponding four objective-coefficient statistics. These features describe immediate LP quality and numerical scale. They do not distinguish two similarly efficacious rows when one acts on discrete route choices and the other on continuous event times. In the present model, that distinction corresponds directly to changing a process/resource combination versus tightening the timing of an existing combination.

Starting from the 13 generic HEM features, variables are partitioned by solver metadata into binary, general integer, objective-active continuous, continuous auxiliary, and other roles. The coefficient mass of role g in cut i is

$$p_{ig} = \frac{\sum_{j:x_j \in g} |a_{ij}|}{\sum_j |a_{ij}| + \varepsilon}. \tag{27}$$

Equation (27) is the fraction of absolute cut-coefficient mass carried by a mathematical variable role. Beyond the five role masses, the added features are mass on variables with two finite global bounds, positive-coefficient mass, discrete–continuous coupling $4(p_{iB}+p_{iI})(p_{iC_{\text{obj}}}+p_{iC_{\text{aux}}})$, the largest non-residual role mass, and normalized role entropy. The resulting vector has 23 dimensions. Roles are identified solely from SCIP variable types, objective coefficients, and global bounds; neither variable names nor equipment labels are read, so variable renaming leaves the representation unchanged.

HEM uses a hierarchical "count policy + ordered-subset policy" decomposition: its high level predicts the number of cuts from a sequence representation, while its low level uses an LSTM encoder–decoder with pointer attention to select cuts sequentially [27, 30]. Building on this hierarchy, the proposed selector introduces a role-aware grouped gated encoder before the LSTM, a role-submodular completion step after the pointer sequence, and width-three beam search during formal inference, which together form the complete RDMCT-HBS selection pipeline.

3.3. Role-aware encoding and hierarchical sequence decoding

Let m_t be the number of candidates retained at separation callback t. For candidate cut i, write the 23D input as $x_i = [x_i^H; x_i^R]$, where $x_i^H \in \mathbb{R}^{13}$ contains the generic HEM features and $x_i^R \in \mathbb{R}^{10}$ contains the proposed role-aware features. The full vector is first layer-normalized; the two feature groups are then projected separately into the common hidden space and fused by an elementwise gate generated from all 23 features:

$$\begin{aligned} \widetilde{x}_i &= \mathrm{LN}(x_i), \\ u_i^H &= W_H \widetilde{x}_i^H + b_H, \qquad u_i^R = W_R \widetilde{x}_i^R + b_R, \\ g_i &= \sigma(W_g \widetilde{x}_i + b_g), \qquad z_i = g_i \odot u_i^H + (1 - g_i) \odot u_i^R. \end{aligned} \tag{28}$$

Here $z_i \in \mathbb{R}^{128}$ is the fused candidate embedding. Unlike a single projection of the 23D vector, the two branches preserve generic LP quality and mathematical-role structure separately, while g_i determines their candidate-specific contribution in each hidden dimension. Thus two cuts with similar efficacy but different concentration on discrete route variables or continuous timing variables can remain distinguishable. This grouped gated adapter is a structural change to HEM's input representation introduced in this work.

The fused candidates, in the deterministic order established by Step 1, are passed through a single-layer LSTM encoder:

$$(h_i, c_i) = \mathrm{LSTM}(z_i, h_{i-1}, c_{i-1}), \qquad i = 1, \dots, m_t. \tag{29}$$

The states h_i turn local cut descriptors into context-dependent candidate representations and are used by both the high-level retained-count policy and the low-level ordered selector. A 128D hidden state is used to encode the ordered candidates into a contextual sequence representation. Fixing the input order also makes the encoded sequence reproducible for an identical candidate pool.

At low-level decoding step r, the decoder state d_r and all encoder states h_i are used for one glimpse attention followed by pointer attention. Let $M_{ri} = -\infty$ if candidate i already appears in the prefix and $M_{ri} = 0$ otherwise. Then

$$\begin{aligned} a_{ri} &= v_g^\top \tanh(W_e h_i + W_d d_r) + M_{ri}, \\ \alpha_{ri} &= \mathrm{softmax}_i(a_{ri}), \\ \bar{h}_r &= \sum_i \alpha_{ri} h_i, \\ b_{ri} &= v_p^\top \tanh(U_e h_i + U_g \bar{h}_r) + M_{ri}, \\ P(i_r = i \mid i_{1:r-1}, S_t) &= \mathrm{softmax}_i(b_{ri}). \end{aligned} \tag{30}$$

Equation (30) makes the sequential dependence explicit. The pointer does not score each cut independently: the selected prefix changes the decoder state and therefore the next distribution; masking prevents repetition; and the glimpse first summarizes the candidate pool conditional on the current prefix. The resulting sequence model combines contextual candidate encoding, prefix-aware pointer decoding, and the proposed representation and completion stages into one role-aware selector.

Training keeps stochastic sampling from the policy for exploration. During formal inference, instead of committing to one path at every step, the method maintains $B = 3$ partial sequences. For parent beam $b = (i_1, \dots, i_{r-1})$ and an unselected extension j, the accumulated score is

$$L_r(b \oplus j) = L_{r-1}(b) + \log P(i_r = j \mid b, S_t). \tag{31}$$

All parent-beam–candidate extensions are compared and the three largest L_r values are retained. After the high-level target length k_t is reached, the best sequence is passed to the completion stage. This beam procedure preserves multiple high-probability partial sequences during decoding, reduces early commitment, and works jointly with the subsequent policy-anchored role-submodular completion to inject variable-role structure into the final selected set.

3.4. Stepwise selection from candidate pool to ordered cuts

At separation callback t, the method executes the following sequence.

Step 1: form the candidate pool. SCIP first generates and validates candidate rows C_t with its own separators. To avoid traversing the complete sparse support of thousands of rows, the method uses SCIP's inexpensive efficacy accessor to retain at most 128 candidates. Ties are broken by original index for deterministic input. Forced cuts remain under solver control and are not placed in the learned ranking.

Step 2: compute and encode the state. The 13 HEM and 10 role-aware features are extracted for every row, with role masses, dominant role, and structural entropy retained as metadata. Equation (28) then performs grouped gated fusion and Eq. (29) produces contextual candidate states. The encoded candidate set is S_t.

Step 3: determine the retained count. The high-level policy outputs a tanh-bounded action in $[-1, 1]$, which is mapped to a retained fraction ρ_t. The fraction is then clipped by the global 0.2 cap, SCIP's round-specific limit, and the implementation cap of 16 cuts, producing k_t. When enough candidates exist, at least two rows are retained to prevent repeated callbacks from degenerating to an empty selection.

Step 4: construct the candidate order. At low-level step r, the pointer policy conditions on S_t and the selected prefix $i_{1:r-1}$ to score all remaining candidates. Selected indices are masked with negative infinity and cannot be repeated. The joint high- and low-level policy is

$$\pi_\theta(k_t, i_{1:k_t} \mid S_t) = \pi_\theta^H(k_t \mid S_t) \prod_{r=1}^{k_t} \pi_\theta^L(i_r \mid S_t, i_{1:r-1}). \tag{32}$$

Equation (32) means that the high level determines the sequence length and the low level then chooses distinct candidates within that length. Each earlier cut changes both the remaining action set and the decoder state used by later probabilities.

Step 5: beam decoding. The low-level policy samples stochastically during training. At test time, beam search of width three is used. At step r, every partial sequence is extended by every unselected candidate; joint log-probabilities are accumulated, and the three highest-scoring items over all parent-beam–next-candidate pairs are retained. After k_t steps, the best sequence is returned. Unlike one-step greedy decoding, the beam retains an initially lower-ranked prefix whose later joint probability can be higher. This fixed-width neural construction follows the broader use of beam decoding in neural combinatorial optimization [31].

Step 6: role-submodular completion. A sequence based only on joint probability can still repeatedly cover one variable role. The first $\lceil 0.25k_t \rceil$ pointer candidates are retained as policy anchors. The remaining policy order is merged with a heuristic tail sorted by instantaneous structural quality q_i, and at most $2k_t$ rows form expansion pool $\mathcal{R}_t$. For $S \subseteq \mathcal{R}_t$, define

$$F_t(S) = \sum_{i \in S} (0.35 q_i + 0.20 r_i) + 0.25 \sum_{g \in \mathcal{G}} d_g \sqrt{\sum_{i \in S} p_{ig}} + \frac{0.20}{|\mathcal{R}_t|} \sum_{u \in \mathcal{R}_t} \max_{i \in S} s_{ui}, \tag{33}$$

where r_i is the normalized pointer-rank prior, d_g is the demand share of role g in the expansion pool, and s_{ui} is clipped cosine similarity on generic-quality and role-mass descriptors. The score q_i combines efficacy, violation, integral support, recognized-role ratio, dominant-role ratio, and structural entropy. In Eq. (33), the first term retains instantaneous quality and the learned order; the square-root coverage term gives diminishing marginal gain to repeated role mass; and the final term makes the selected cuts represent the main structures in the pool. Starting from the anchors, the method recomputes the marginal gain of every unselected candidate and adds the largest until k_t cuts have been selected. The nonnegative modular, concave-over-modular, and facility-location terms form a monotone submodular objective, so the residual greedy completion after fixing anchors and the expansion pool inherits the standard $1 - 1/e$ approximation property [32].

Finally, the k_t selected rows are placed at the front of the returned array in the chosen order, while all other candidates remain as an unselected suffix. SCIP adds only the prefix to the current LP. One callback therefore completes six operations: inexpensive truncation, feature extraction, count prediction, sequence decoding, structural completion, and return to SCIP.

Algorithm 1: Cut selection by parallel hierarchical REINFORCE and beam search

Algorithm steps

Input: SCIP-validated rows C_t, high-level policy π_θ^H, low-level pointer policy π_θ^L, beam width $B = 3$, and the current SCIP cut limit.
Output: Ordered cut prefix $S_t^\star = (i_1, \ldots, i_{k_t})$ and the unselected suffix returned to SCIP.
1. Train the policies. Two workers collect rollouts in parallel with terminal reward $R = -\text{PDI}$; a central learner applies hierarchical REINFORCE with separate EMA baselines and synchronous Adam updates. Fix the parameters for formal inference.
2. Form the pool. Sort by efficacy, break ties by original index, and retain at most 128 rows.
3. Encode the state. Compute 13 HEM features, ten role-aware features, and role-mass metadata; apply grouped projections, sigmoid-gated fusion, and LSTM encoding.
4. Determine the count. Predict the retained fraction with π_θ^H and obtain k_t after the 0.2 fraction cap, SCIP round limit, and 16-cut implementation cap.
5. Initialize the beam. Set $\mathcal{B}_0$ to the empty sequence with log probability zero.
6. Expand. For $r = 1, \ldots, k_t$, obtain masked conditional probabilities from one glimpse plus pointer attention, extend every prefix in $\mathcal{B}_{r-1}$ by every unselected candidate, and accumulate log probability.
7. Prune. Retain the three highest joint-probability parent–candidate extensions as $\mathcal{B}_r$; after the loop, take the leading sequence in $\mathcal{B}_{k_t}$.
8. Fix anchors. Retain its first $\lceil 0.25k_t \rceil$ rows as policy anchors A_t.
9. Form the expansion pool. Merge the remaining pointer order with structural-quality order, remove duplicates, and keep at most $2k_t$ rows as $\mathcal{R}_t$.
10. Complete submodularly. Set $S \leftarrow A_t$; while $|S| < k_t$, add the $i \in \mathcal{R}_t \setminus S$ maximizing $F_t(S \cup \{i\}) - F_t(S)$.
11. Return. Return $S_t^\star$ in anchor-then-completion order; leave all other rows in the suffix and outside the current LP.

3.5. Reinforcement-learning training and exact-solver interface

One time-limited SCIP solve forms a rollout, with its terminal PDI used as the cost. The current policy is executed in every eligible cut-selection callback. For replay, the agent records the high-level fraction and low-level sampled sequence at the first valid candidate set of that rollout, and the PDI of the complete solve is returned to both policies. Writing $R = -\text{PDI}$ as a re-

ward, the low-level estimator is

$$\widehat{\nabla_\theta J} = \frac{1}{B}\sum_{b=1}^{B}(R_b - \bar{R}_{\mathrm{EMA}})\nabla_\theta \log \pi_\theta(\tau_b), \qquad \bar{R}_{\mathrm{EMA}} \leftarrow 0.9\bar{R}_{\mathrm{EMA}} + 0.1\bar{R}. \tag{34}$$

Equation (34) is batch REINFORCE with an exponential-moving-average baseline; B is the rollout batch and τ_b is the recorded cut sequence in rollout b. Equivalently, the code minimizes PDI-cost advantage times log probability. Low-level log probability is averaged over sequence length so that a longer cut sequence does not produce a larger gradient merely because it contains more terms. The high-level policy uses the same PDI cost and an independent EMA baseline and is updated every two epochs; both gradient norms are clipped at 2. The implementation adopts the A3C idea of parallel environments to reduce sample correlation, but a central learner updates parameters synchronously after the batch is collected. It is therefore parallel hierarchical REINFORCE rather than asynchronous actor–critic [33, 34].

Training uses five instances and five random seeds. Each seed has two workers, each completing four 30-s/1024-MB rollouts per epoch, for eight rollouts per epoch and 60 epochs. Initial Adam learning rates are 10^{-4} for the low-level policy and 5×10^{-4} for the high-level policy and are multiplied by 0.96 every ten epochs. Training uses stochastic decoding and formal inference uses beam width three. Every configuration–seed combination uses the fixed epoch-60 parameters without benchmark- or test-set checkpoint selection. HEM-13D, feature-only 23D, and the complete 23D method are trained separately so that weights are never mixed across input semantics or completion environments.

RDMCT-HBS only orders and selects valid rows already generated by SCIP, and SPBS submits only solutions checked in the complete model. Neither changes the objective, constraints, integrality, or bound logic. The learned components therefore change the search path and finite-time bound convergence, whereas feasibility and optimality retain the same meaning as in default SCIP.

4. Manufacturing-system experiments and decision analysis

4.1. Experimental design and metrics

The experiments follow the manufacturing-system decision chain and address four questions. First, can configuration inputs be mapped consistently to a complete timeline satisfying dual-source routes, full occupancy, cleaning, and shared-resource constraints while exposing the occupancy pattern of each process mode? Second, after the throughput structure is determined, does two-stage optimization improve waiting and cadence under the same total budget? Third, do SPBS and structure-aware cut selection improve finite-time plan delivery and primal–dual convergence, respectively? Fourth, can the decision chain continue to return verifiable plans as scale, mixed-flow composition, operating parameters, and the data distribution change? The evidence comprises four small exact checks, 2700 nominal baseline and ablation runs, 960 paired SPBS runs, 1500 equal-budget workflow runs, 300 factorial runs, 80 one-factor sensitivity runs, and 729 distribution-shift runs on 40–64-wafer batches, for 6273 solves in total. All 6041 saved incumbents pass both SCIP validation and an independent post-solve check against the same serialized MILP. Wafer-level and resource-level Gantt charts are additionally exported for the 8- and 16-wafer cases to verify process overlap, robot occupancy, cleaning actions, and end-to-end completion time directly.

The MILP, SCIP version, instances, and random seeds are frozen, and each comparison family uses common time and memory limits. Let $P(t)$ denote the primal bound of the minimization problem at time t, namely the objective value of the best incumbent, and let $D(t)$ denote the dual bound, namely the global lower bound certified by the search tree. Define $\Delta(t) = |P(t) - D(t)|$, $m(t) = \min\{|P(t)|, |D(t)|\}$, and $M(t) = \max\{|P(t)|, |D(t)|\}$. When the two bounds are finite, have the same sign, and differ, the terminal relative primal–dual gap is taken directly from SCIP `getGap()` as

$$G_{\mathrm{end}} = 100\,\frac{\Delta(T)}{m(T)}. \tag{35}$$

SCIP sets $G_{\mathrm{end}} = 0$ when the bounds coincide and returns $+\infty$ when they have opposite signs or valid bounds are not both available. Equation (35) normalizes by the smaller absolute bound and consequently does not cap G_{end} at 100%. A value above 100% indicates that the incumbent and the certified lower bound remain widely separated at the time limit; it is not a feasibility or percentage-conversion error.

SCIP uses a different bounded normalization for the primal–dual integral. Define the instantaneous integral gap as

$$g_{\mathrm{PDI}}(t) = 100\,\frac{\Delta(t)}{M(t)}, \qquad \mathrm{PDI} = \int_0^T g_{\mathrm{PDI}}(t)\,\mathrm{d}t. \tag{36}$$

Equation (36) applies when the bounds are finite, have the same sign, and differ; SCIP sets $g_{\mathrm{PDI}}(t) = 0$ for coincident bounds and $g_{\mathrm{PDI}}(t) = 100$ otherwise. The instantaneous integral gap is therefore bounded to $[0, 100]$; lower PDI means that the bound gap closes earlier. PDI is zero only if the gap is zero for almost the entire timed horizon, whereas $G_{\mathrm{end}} = 0$ only states that optimality is proved at termination. Both quantities are exported from SCIP statistics and are neither clipped nor redefined during plotting [28, 29].

The manufacturing instance is the inferential unit: random repeats are first aggregated within an instance, after which paired instance differences use nonparametric 95% bootstrap intervals, Wilcoxon signed-rank tests, and Holm correction within each registered analysis family [35]. Time-limited runs remain in the summaries so that random seeds are not treated as independent manufacturing evidence. Full hardware, budgets, tolerances, instance lists, and hyperparameters are provided in the supplementary reproducibility package.

Table 3 lists the frozen configuration used to produce the 8- and 16-wafer Gantt charts. Two rotating chambers share the VTR, while product and dummy wafers compete for robots, load locks, and chamber spaces along their respective

routes; cleaning counts, rotation, and transfer times are represented in the same MILP. Each displayed solution passes SCIP `checkSol` and an independent post-solve check before export, so the charts provide both a structural comparison and auditable feasibility evidence.

4.2. *Process mode, time convention, and two-stage operational value*

Steady-state studies of multi-space CTs commonly evaluate equipment efficiency through cycle time or throughput [20]. For the finite batches studied here, the experiment reports both exact makespan and the equivalent throughput derived from it.

Table 4 summarizes exact mode comparisons for 8-, 16-, 17-, and 20-wafer batches under the same topology and transport and cleaning parameters. This experiment adopts an equal-single-exposure-time convention: the single 4×1 exposure and each of the two 2×2 exposures are 180 s. It therefore represents operation in which every recipe step has the same residence time. All six 8- and 16-wafer configurations reach zero terminal gap, and each is confirmed by the full cross of five solver seeds and five training seeds.

Under this process-time convention, pure 4×1 gives the shortest makespan and highest equivalent throughput at all four batch sizes. The Gantt charts show the system mechanism behind this difference: 2×2 operation must maintain two adjacent exposures and dummy PW pairs at the head and tail of the chain, while mixed operation must coordinate both occupancy logics on the same VTR and chamber timeline. These additional equipment actions jointly produce the completion-time differences reported in Table 4.

Waiting-time constraints can propagate to manufacturing-system output and control performance [13]. For the same 600-s total budget, the complete two-stage workflow assigns 540 s to the main solve and up to 60 s to refinement, whereas the one-stage control assigns all 600 s to the main solve. Figure 6 shows that the two-stage workflow reduces total route wait, maximum wait, cadence coefficient of variation, and cadence deviation by 51.91%, 68.89%, 39.70%, and 94.05%, respectively. All four paired instance differences remain significant after Holm correction, demonstrating that the two-stage workflow markedly improves waiting and cadence quality under the same total budget.

The quadratic-objective control and the complete linear refinement both use the 540+up-to-60-s split. Linear refinement yields a cadence deviation of 22.04, 63.38% below the quadratic profile's 60.18, and the matched difference remains significant after Holm correction ($p = 0.0377$); total route wait, maximum wait, and cadence coefficient of variation are similar overall. The linear objective therefore produces a more regular processing cadence under the same budget.

4.3. *SPBS and structure-aware cut selection*

The paired SPBS study uses 48 instances and ten paired seeds per instance. Relative to the no-start condition, precomputed SPBS increases incumbent availability from 51.67% to 100%, a gain of 48.33 percentage points (95% interval $[34.58, 62.29]$).



Figure 4: Optimal schedules for the 8-wafer instance. Rows represent pure 4×1, pure 2×2, and 4:4 mixed operation; the left and right columns give wafer-level and resource-level views. The horizontal axis is time (s), and colors distinguish transport, AL alignment, load-lock operations, chamber loading/unloading, chamber processing, return/downstream handling, and waiting/occupancy. The three $C_{\max}$ values are 610, 768, and 834 s, corresponding to equivalent throughputs of 47.21, 37.50, and 34.53 wafers/h.

Mean PDI falls from 27473.05 to 20278.78, a decrease of 7194.27 or 26.19% (95% interval $[5145.78, 9317.61]$). Both paired differences remain significant after Holm correction ($p = 2.55\times10^{-5}$ and $p = 3.46\times10^{-8}$). These results show that SPBS substantially increases finite-time access to complete feasible schedules and improves primal–dual search efficiency.

In the 2700 nominal runs sharing the same SPBS incumbent, pure SCIP is the solver baseline, HEM-13D is the direct learning-based baseline, and RDMCT-HBS is the complete method. The remaining settings isolate the marginal effects of role-aware representation, beam search, adaptive cut scoring (ACS), and structural completion. All learning-based settings share the training instances, random seeds, candidate cap, hidden dimension, and solve budget. Relative to HEM-13D, RDMCT-HBS reduces mean PDI from 16823.18 to 16585.70 (1.41%), mean solution time from 219.65 to 218.32 s (0.61%), and the mean terminal relative gap defined by Eq. (35) from 127.24% to 126.01% (0.97%), while increasing the proven-optimal rate from 62.4% to 63.2% (0.80 percentage points); all 500 runs return feasible solutions (Fig. 8). Terminal gaps above 100% indicate a large remaining primal–dual separation in some time-limited runs. Under the same budget, the complete method improves both the integrated search trajectory and terminal certificate quality relative to HEM-13D. The ablations locate the principal mean improvement in the role-aware rep-

Table 3: Frozen configuration for the 8- and 16-wafer Gantt experiments under the equal-single-exposure-time convention.

Group	Parameter and value	Group	Parameter and value
Rotating chambers	CH2 and CH3; two shared rotating PMs with four spaces each	Process time	180 s for 4×1; 180 s per 2×2 exposure
Cleaning	Triggered every 10 process cycles per chamber; pure-dummy cleaning 500 s	Chamber motion	180° rotation 2 s; inter-action gap 1 s
ATR	One dual-hand robot, capacity 2; load/unload 4 s, complete loaded transfer 11 s	VTR	One four-hand robot, capacity 4; loaded transfer 4 s, empty reposition 4 s
ATR details	LL–LP empty return 6 s; PW-pair exchange at AL 8 s	AL	Capacity 1; minimum alignment occupancy 20 s per wafer
Load locks	LLupper pump/reset 30 s per slot; LLlower vent/reset 25 s	LL capacity	Two independent slots in each of upper and lower LLs
Material source	LP1–LP4, capacity 25 wafers each	Dummy wafers	Eight reusable wafers, four per chamber; storage capacity 10
Batch and model	Product batch size 4; 13 modeled process steps	Chamber bound	At most 15 4×1 batch slots per PM
Model bounds	Big-M = 10000; module and robot residency bounds 10000 s	Waiting option	Avoidable-wait hard cap 0, meaning that this optional cap is disabled
Objective	`compact_resource_idle`; process mode `auto`	Policy	Frozen training seed 1, epoch 60, 23 features
Decoder and cuts	Beam width 3; cut pool 128, at most 16 cuts selected per round	Solver	SCIP seed 1; SPBS warm start for instances containing 2×2
Two-stage solve	Stage 1 minimizes $C_{\max}$; stage 2 uses linear stabilization	Export check	SCIP `checkSol` and independent validation for every solution

Table 4: Exact $C_{\max}$ and equivalent throughput of the three processing modes at four batch sizes.

Batch size	Pure 4×1 $C_{\max}$ (s)	Pure 4×1 WPH	Pure 2×2 $C_{\max}$ (s)	Pure 2×2 WPH	Mixed $C_{\max}$ (s)	Mixed WPH
8	610	47.21	768	37.50	834	34.53
16	944	61.02	1136	50.70	1170	49.23
17	1002	61.08	1244	49.20	1251	48.92
20	1106	65.10	1320	54.55	1410	51.06



Figure 5: Optimal schedules for the 16-wafer instance. Rows represent pure 4×1, pure 2×2, and 8:8 mixed operation; the left and right columns give wafer-level and resource-level views. The horizontal axis is time (s), with colors defined as in Fig. 4. The three $C_{\max}$ values are 944, 1136, and 1170 s, corresponding to equivalent throughputs of 61.02, 50.70, and 49.23 wafers/h.

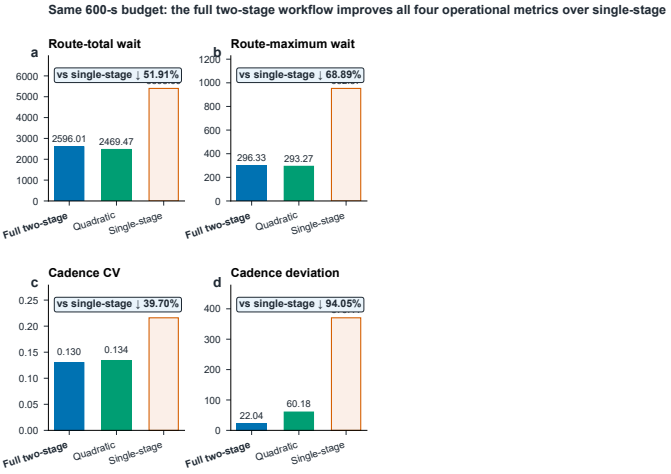


Figure 6: Final-schedule quality under the same 600-s total budget. a–d, total route wait, maximum route wait, cadence coefficient of variation, and cadence deviation; 1500 runs in total, with observed means labeled above the bars.

resentation and show that structural completion and beam decoding provide complementary contributions in the complete method.

These results support an explanation consistent with the model structure: candidate cuts do not act on equivalent objects. By distinguishing discrete routes, continuous event times, and their coupling, the policy can combine cuts with different structural roles more consistently; policy-anchored completion further reduces repeated coverage of a single role. The complete RDMCT-HBS therefore attains the lowest observed mean PDI and mean solution time in the unified nominal experiment while also improving terminal gap and proven-optimal rate.

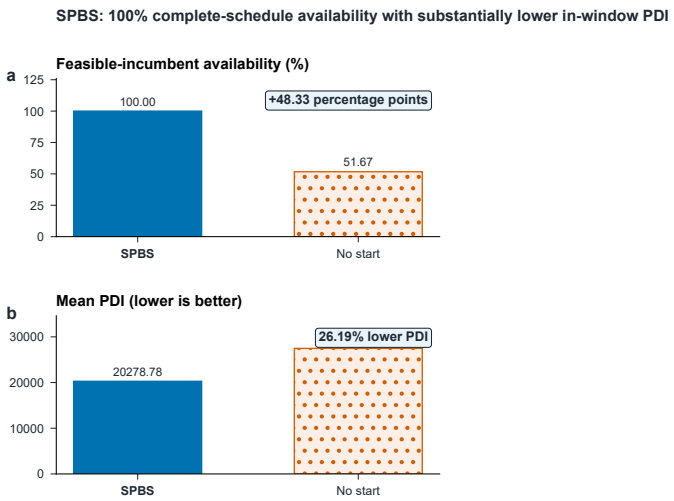


Figure 7: Effect of precomputed SPBS on primal search. a, incumbent availability; b, mean PDI. Each condition has $n = 480$; observed values are labeled directly.

4.4. Scale, recipe composition, and computational difficulty

The factorial design contains $4 \times 5 \times 3 = 60$ wafer-count–recipe-composition–process-scale cells with five solver seeds per cell, for 300 runs. Figure 9 shows a sharp transition. All 75 runs at both 8 and 16 wafers prove optimality, with mean PDI values of 28.13 and 1876.54 and mean solution times of 0.34 and 33.86 s. At 24 and 32 wafers, the proven-optimal rates fall to 36% and 20%, mean PDI rises to 31155.94 and 32959.89, and mean solution time reaches 408.55 and 433.20 s.

The prespecified PDI factorial model has $R^2 = 0.998$. Under the 1:1 mixed recipe, the additional interaction coefficients at 24 and 32 wafers are 37729.48 and 40788.63, while the 95% intervals for the process-scale main effect and all prespecified process-scale interactions include zero. Over the tested 0.9–1.1 process-scale range, computational difficulty is driven primarily by the interaction between batch size and mixed-flow composition, with a comparatively small process-scale effect.

4.5. Operation under parameter perturbations

Prior CT studies show that cleaning actions and their triggering conditions alter robot-task sequences, cycle time, and wafer delay [17, 19]. The one-factor sensitivity study therefore covers eight prescribed perturbations of transport, processing, cleaning interval, and vacuum-domain dummy inventory, for 80 runs. Every run returns a solver-checked feasible schedule and 20 runs prove optimality; scenario mean PDI ranges from 28899.41 to 42478.32. A longer cleaning interval gives the lowest mean PDI and slower transport the highest, showing that cleaning frequency and shared-robot transport cadence materially shape search difficulty. The framework nevertheless returns a feasible schedule in every prescribed perturbation scenario.

4.6. Feasible-schedule delivery under distribution shift

The distribution-shift suite enlarges batches to 40–64 wafers and changes mixed-flow composition, producing 729 runs over

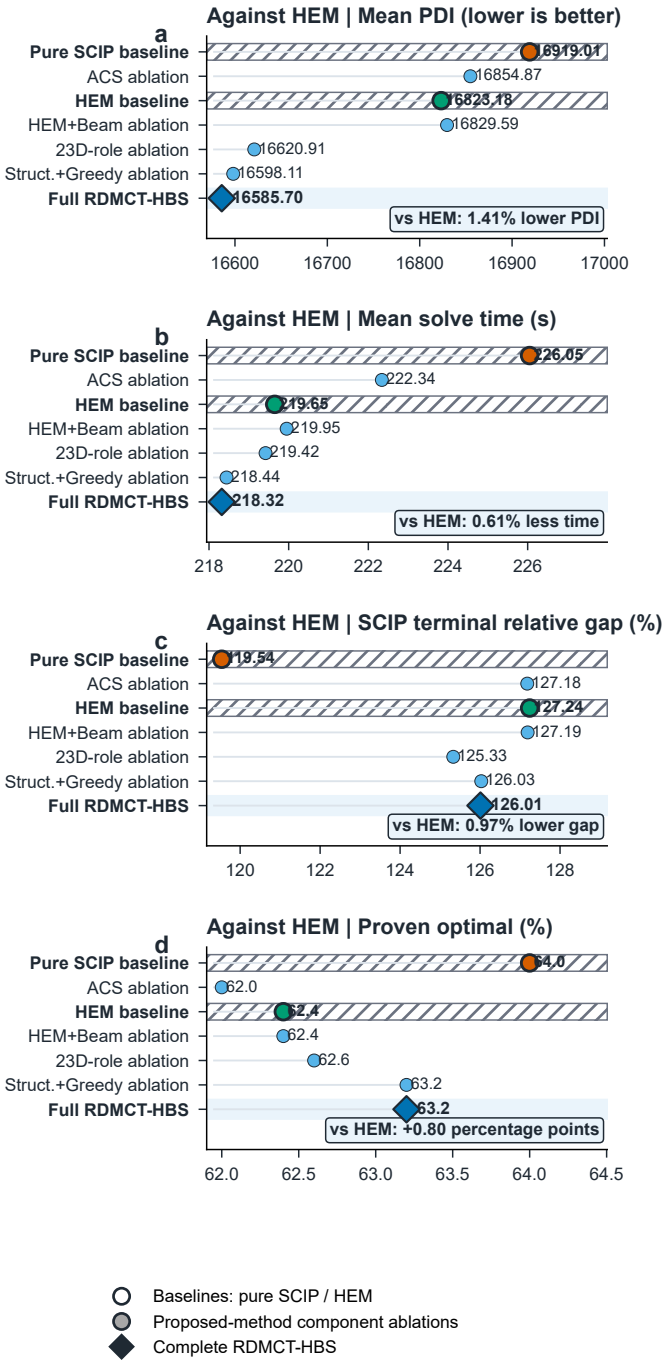


Figure 8: Baseline and component-ablation experiment under a shared SPBS incumbent. Pure SCIP and HEM-13D are the two baselines, RDMCT-HBS is the complete method, and the remaining entries are component-level ablations or single-component variants. Panels report mean PDI integrated using Eq. (36), mean solution time, SCIP mean terminal relative gap from Eq. (35) (which may exceed 100%), and proven-optimal rate over 2700 runs. Values and improvements over HEM are labeled directly. The blue diamond marks the complete RDMCT-HBS, orange and green circles mark the two baselines, and light-blue circles mark component ablations; line, marker, and hatch styles provide redundant encoding.

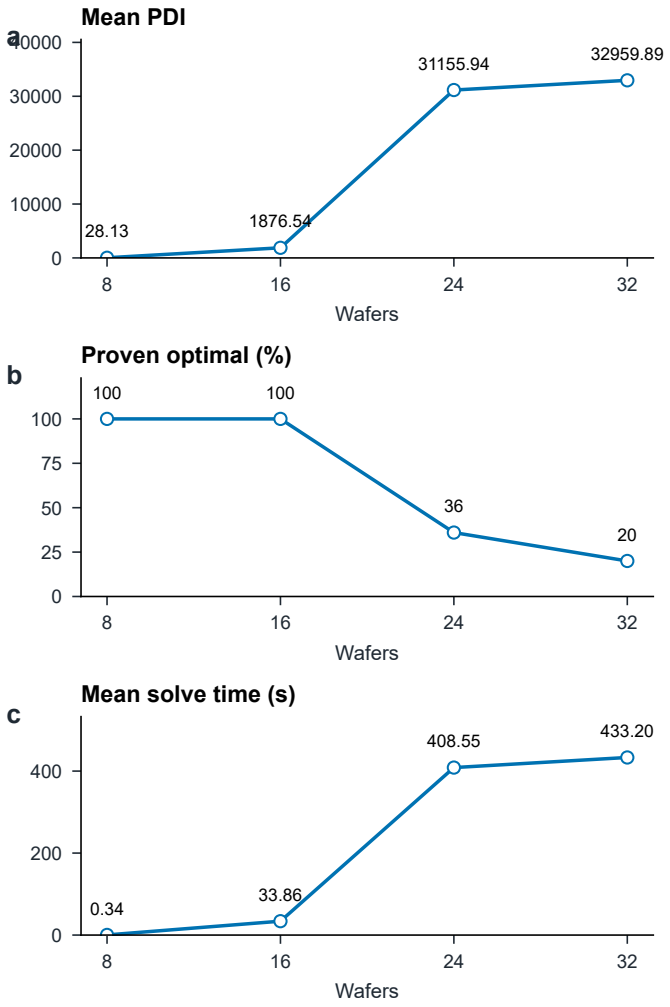


Figure 9: Scale transition in the 300-run factorial experiment. a, mean PDI; b, proven-optimal rate; c, mean solution time. Each wafer count contains 75 runs and observed values are labeled directly.

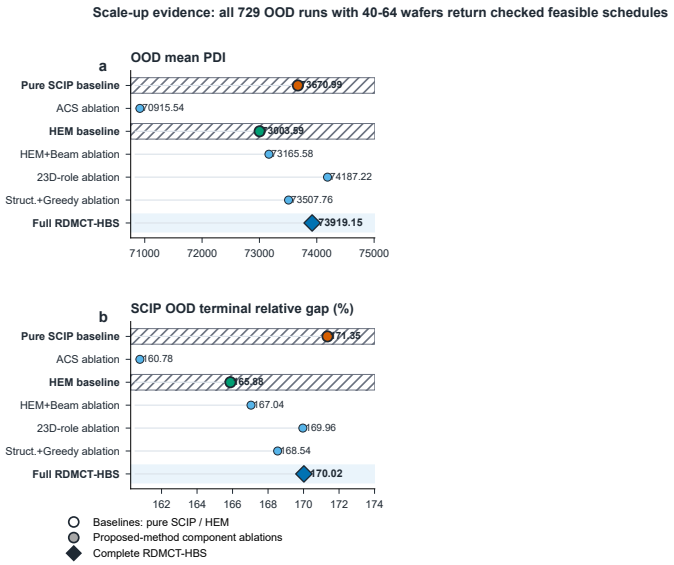


Figure 10: Distribution-shift experiment with 40–64 wafers. a, instance-first mean PDI for the pure-SCIP and HEM baselines, the complete RDMCT-HBS, and its component ablations; b, SCIP mean terminal relative gap computed from Eq. (35) without a 100% upper bound. All 729 runs return checked feasible schedules; observed values are labeled directly. The ablations test component contribution and necessity under distribution shift.

nine shifted manufacturing scenarios. All 729 runs return an incumbent that passes SCIP and independent post-solve checks, showing that the SPBS–MILP–SCIP solution pipeline reliably delivers verifiable schedules at the larger shifted scale.

In the distribution-shift experiment, the adaptive-scoring-only component ablation records the lowest observed mean PDI (70915.54) and terminal gap (160.78%). The corresponding values are 73919.15 and 170.02% for the complete RDMCT-HBS, and 73670.99 and 171.35% for the pure-SCIP baseline. This result shows that the simpler scoring component is comparatively robust on the 40–64-wafer shift, while the shared SPBS–MILP–SCIP pipeline consistently returns a checked feasible schedule in all 729 runs.

4.7. Manufacturing-system integration and operational implications

The experiments establish three operating patterns. First, when every recipe step lasts 180 s, 4×1 reduces chained exchange and repeated-processing occupancy through one synchronous full-chamber exposure; the additional occupancy of 2×2 and mixed operation arises mainly from adjacent-exposure continuity, dummy PW pairs, and shared-VTR coordination. Second, minimizing $C_{\max}$ determines the throughput structure, whereas low waiting and regular cadence require second-stage shaping; linear refinement significantly improves timeline quality under the same total budget. Third, batch size and mixed-flow composition jointly alter the coupling between discrete routes and continuous timing. SPBS and structure-aware cut selection consequently serve the distinct functions of early feasible-plan delivery and faster convergence of the solver state.

From a system-integration perspective, the framework closes an information loop. Upper-level production control supplies the batch, process modes, and available equipment configuration; the model generates event times for LP release, ATR/VTR transport, chamber processing and cleaning, and wafer return. A lower-level equipment controller can execute these events, while the upper-level system can read completion times, resource-occupancy intervals, and the solution certificate. The sensitivity and 40–64-wafer studies show that this equipment-cell decision layer continues to deliver checked complete timelines under parameter variation and scale expansion. The system contribution is thus a single operating interface connecting physical configuration, material-flow coordination, operating quality, and verifiable solver status.

5. Conclusions

This study addresses a dual-source mixed-flow rotating-chamber cluster tool for PECVD. Because residues from the carbon-containing film process require chamber positions to be protected, dummy wafers maintain full occupancy when prod-

uct wafers are insufficient and during chamber cleaning. Products enter from the atmospheric side, while dummies circulate from vacuum-side storage; their routes meet at the shared VTR and four-position chambers. The proposed two-stage MILP captures 4×1 parallel processing, 2×2 chained processing, dummy reuse, cleaning, residency limits, and shared transport in one model. PW pairs link dual-hand robot motions to chamber occupancy, and event timing and resource ordering convert the two material flows into verifiable deadlock-free operating plans. SPBS and RDMCT-HBS improve early feasible-plan acquisition and finite-time bound convergence, respectively.

Under the same 600-s total budget, the two-stage workflow reduces total route wait, maximum route wait, cadence coefficient of variation, and cadence deviation by 51.91%, 68.89%, 39.70%, and 94.05%, respectively. SPBS increases finite-time incumbent availability from 51.67% to 100% and lowers mean PDI by 26.19%. Relative to HEM-13D, RDMCT-HBS reduces mean PDI, solution time, and terminal gap by 1.41%, 0.61%, and 0.97%, and increases the proven-optimal rate by 0.80 percentage points. Under the equal-single-exposure-time convention, synchronous full-chamber 4×1 processing reduces chained exchange and repeated-processing occupancy. The factorial experiment further identifies the interaction between batch size and mixed-flow composition as the primary source of search difficulty, and all 729 distribution-shift runs on 40–64-wafer instances return checked feasible schedules.

Treating reusable dummies as a second material flow, rather than as an end-batch exception, makes it possible to coordinate full-chamber protection, cleaning, residency waiting, and processing cadence in the same model. Given material sources, process modes, cleaning rules, and resource parameters, the framework returns a checkable equipment-action timeline together with its solution status. It thus provides a common decision basis for finite-batch operation of PECVD rotating-chamber tools. Future work will incorporate stochastic arrivals and equipment disturbances and connect rolling optimization to the physical equipment-control process.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Lincong Wei was responsible for Conceptualization, Methodology, Software, Validation, Formal analysis, Investigation, Data curation, Visualization, Writing – original draft, and Writing – review and editing. Lizhen Shao was responsible for Conceptualization, Methodology, Formal analysis, Validation, Writing – review and editing, and Project administration. Wei Wang was responsible for Formal analysis, Investigation, Writing – review and editing, and Supervision. All authors reviewed and approved the final manuscript.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Data and code availability

The data, mathematical instances, trained models, and source code supporting the findings are available from the corresponding author on reasonable request. A permanent public archive will be cited in the version of record.

Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the manuscript preparation process

During the preparation of this work, the authors used OpenAI ChatGPT and Codex to improve language and readability, check LaTeX consistency, and assist with software debugging. After using these tools, the authors reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the publication.

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